

forbidden the railway construction, and work stopped briefly when labourers panicked after mistaking a long iron pipe in the tunnel for a huge serpent.

Tragic consequences

Another prominent tunnel on this line, the Barog Tunnel is the longest along the Kalka–Shimla rail route at 1.1 km. Also known as No. 33, this tunnel was initially designed by Colonel Barog, a British engineer who began by digging from both ends, a common method at the time. When it was discovered that the two ends of the tunnel would never align, Barog was fined Re 1 by the Government for wasting resources.

Humiliated and distraught, he committed suicide. The tunnel was eventually completed by Chief Engineer HS Harrington with the help of Bhalku, a local resident of Chail, whose contributions resulted in the straightest tunnel on the route, and earned him a medal and turban from the then Viceroy, and saint-like status among the locals. This tunnel is still lit using large mirrors, a popular practice for the earlier tunnels as it directed sunlight into the dark passageways.